

Williams's musical journey. The Fourth Symphony's first audience in 1935 was startled by the work's ferocious dissonance and frenetic style, which were later seen as somehow prophetic of World War II, although the composer always rejected this interpretation. But he also stated privately—to Adrian Boult, who conducted the premiere—that the music's inner fury related to the situation of his wife, Adeline, crippled by arthritis from which she would not recover.

Late love and a new life

After this musical outburst came its polar opposite, the *Serenade to Music*. This was written for the 1938 jubilee concert of the composer's longstanding supporter, the conductor Sir Henry Wood, who asked for a work involving 16 leading solo singers of the day; Vaughan Williams took the words from Shakespeare's play *The Merchant of Venice*. The music's radiant serenity had an immediate impulse: a meeting with Ursula Wood, a young army wife with a liking for poetry, had led to a passionate affair. Before the deaths of Ursula's husband during World War II and of Adeline in 1951, the lovers kept their relationship secret from almost everyone, except Adeline herself. In 1943, Ursula had a pregnancy terminated.

The closeness of this unlikely couple, followed by their marriage in 1953, contributed greatly to the remarkable creative energy of Vaughan Williams's final years. The Sixth Symphony of 1948 explored a turbulent yet at times also ethereally calm sound-world far removed from anything resembling traditional "Englishness." The premiere at the Royal Opera House, Covent